

Don't Hide From Your Flesh

Isaiah 58 says that when the fast God has chosen begins to work, "then shall your health spring forth speedily." That is not only spiritual health; it is natural health too. Fasting starts a housecleaning on the inside.

That is why we keep coming back to what Jesus said when the disciples could not cast the demon out of the boy. The problem was not that God was unwilling. Jesus did not say, "This kind comes out only if God gets moved." He said it was because of unbelief, and then He said:

| This kind goes not out but by prayer and fasting.

Fasting does not change God. Fasting lines you up with what God has already provided, until your spirit can receive and act without the resistance of the flesh.

Romans says:

| If Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin; but the Spirit is life because of righteousness.

At the new birth, two positional truths came into force. Your spirit was raised up and seated with Christ in heavenly places. Your body was declared dead because of sin. Your spirit has a legal position in Christ, and your flesh has no legal right to rule.

Prayer in tongues, meditation in the Word, worship, and fellowship with God enforce the position of your spirit. Fasting enforces the position of your body. It tells the body, "You are not the ruler here. You were declared dead because of sin, and you do not have the right to dominate the new creation."

That is why fasting works for a believer in a way it cannot work for someone outside of Christ. Gandhi fasted. Buddha fasted. Many people in false religions fast. But they do not have the positional truth of a recreated spirit seated in Christ and a body legally declared dead. Without that truth, fasting can open people to deception and the wrong spiritual realm. In Christ, fasting enforces what God has already said about you.

There can be a ceiling over your life that is not God. It is not His unwillingness. It is not that He is holding back. Much of the time it is flesh. The flesh keeps the spirit from rising into what is already available.

When fasting is joined with prayer, worship, the Word, and fellowship with God, it begins to break that ceiling. It is like taking the lid off. You may have believed for something for years, and then suddenly the realm of the Spirit changes. I remember believing for a new car, and it was years

before it came. But when the ceiling broke, the answer came in a way that showed me the delay had not been in God.

Fasting executes the truth that your body has no right and no power to reign over your spirit. It puts the flesh under, so the life of the spirit can move.

I heard of a missionary in Mexico who came to the place where resurrection was no longer only a doctrine to him. A baby had drowned, and when he was faced with it, he ran. That shook him. He went back and began searching the Scriptures for every place where God raised the dead.

Then he began to fast. Not once casually, but relentlessly. He fasted long fasts and series of fasts. He drove the Word into himself until resurrection was no longer something outside him. It became something his spirit could stand on.

Later his own child drowned. This time he did not run. He held that child and stood on the Word for about an hour and a half until life came back. The reports around his ministry credited his team with many resurrections in Mexico.

The miracle was not only that the dead were raised. The miracle was that he got people to fast and pray until the Word became stronger in them than fear, grief, and natural evidence.

Isaiah 58 describes the fast God has chosen:

Is not this the fast that I have chosen? To loose the bands of wickedness, to undo the heavy burdens, to let the oppressed go free, and that ye break every yoke?

This fast is not about trying to impress heaven. Earlier in the chapter the people ask why God has not seen their fasting. But God is showing them that fasting is not so you can be heard on high while remaining unchanged down here. Fasting is so you can hear God on low, where the flesh has been resisting Him.

Then Isaiah says:

Hide not thyself from thine own flesh.

That is the key. The day you begin to fast is the day you decide to stop hiding from the part of you that does not care.

Isaiah 61 says:

The Spirit of the Lord God is upon me; because the Lord hath anointed me to preach good tidings unto the meek...

Jesus read that in the synagogue and said it was fulfilled. Before He entered that ministry, He went through forty days of fasting in the wilderness. The fast of Isaiah 58 was chosen for Him, and it is chosen for us too.

"Hide not yourself from your own flesh" does not mean you must physically avoid people. There is a fast where a husband and wife may separate for a time by consent. There is also the fast Jesus described, where you wash your face, go about your business, and do not appear to men to fast.

This is not about hiding from other people. It is about not hiding from what is in you.

When you fast, you come face to face with the places where your flesh has quit caring. The naked, the captive, the poor, the hungry, the sick, the lost, the healed, the delivered, the broken. Somewhere inside, flesh can become hard and say, "That is not my problem." Fasting exposes that.

Missionaries can become hard. Preachers can become hard. You can see need so constantly that you begin protecting yourself from it. I have watched poverty in foreign countries and seen how easy it is for people to become numb just to survive the sight of it. Traveling the world made me thankful, but it also showed me how flesh can wall itself off from suffering.

Rodney Howard-Browne told of being in a foreign country, riding in a limousine, and seeing people in need outside the window. The driver told him not to give money. But compassion would not let him sit there insulated from what was in front of him. He gave anyway.

That is what fasting begins to confront. It confronts whatever in us is content to ride past pain with the window up.

Mother Teresa saw a boy in a garbage dump in Calcutta, scavenging while holding his little sister. That sight became part of the call that drove her out of the convent and into the slums. She took a vow of poverty as a servant. If she had two shirts and met someone with none, one shirt was no longer hers. If she had two toothbrushes and met someone with none, one toothbrush belonged to the person in need.

At first they stoned her. She cried out that she could nourish children, teach them to read, comfort the dying, and clean the diseased. Eventually she became trusted, and then help and funding came. She stopped hiding from the flesh that would rather look away.

I know what this means because I came close to failure myself. Before one of my fasts, I was in trouble. My emotions were beaten back. I had no peace. I kept the television on. My eyes looked like road maps. I could not sleep without noise. I could hardly read the Bible. I was preaching the same messages, but inside I was losing ground.

At the Mile High Conference with Wally and Marilyn Hickey, the devil tried to push me across a line into immorality. Marilyn helped me get an appointment with Dr. Cho, and when I came home I knew, "This is it."

Rosalie was overseas and unavailable, so I could not run to her to prop me up. I had to keep fasting. Around day sixteen or seventeen, the antagonistic resistance to prayer finally dropped to a manageable level. I could pray. I could read the Bible. The fast forced me to face the part of me that had quit caring.

The second fast was easier, but it still cross-examined me. It showed me ugly things I had not wanted to see. The next fast birthed the message "Peace, the Aggressive Weapon."

Long fasts and series of fasts will bring you to these problems. A series of shorter fasts may take longer, depending on how deep or shallow the problem is, but it will still work if you keep yielding to God.

Do not hide from your flesh means: quit putting off the thing inside you that you do not want to face.

The devil will tell you, "Someday you will get into this. Someday you will pray. Someday you will fast. Someday you will deal with it." That false comfort keeps you from doing the thing that would bring permanent change.

The old wine is not better. The old flesh life is not better. True peace begins when the love of God in you starts loving people, and your peace is no longer controlled by what people do to you.

I do not fast now by fixed lengths the way I used to. I fast by the Spirit and by what is happening in me. Tim once marveled that I could simply stop eating. But the reason I can do that now is because those first fasts built something in my spirit. In the old days, if I set a certain number of days and failed, condemnation would come. Then I learned that God was pleased with any amount of time I gave Him.

That removed the condemnation. If I tried and only made four or five days, the Father was not sitting in heaven docking me. He was pleased that I attempted to do something for Him. So what if I failed the first thirty times? One of those times I was going to get up and make it. And I did.

Some people preach against long fasts because someone may come out of a forty-day fast and not see anything obvious. If you put all your expectation into one visible result, you can be disappointed. But if you understand fasting, you know it still did something.

You cannot fast with the positional truth of Christ working in you and have it accomplish nothing. If you want to speed the process after you recover, go back into shorter fasts. Eat, then fast again. Keep doing it. Eventually there will be a change in the realm of the Spirit and in the things happening around you.

When that change comes, do not take it as a sign that you are ready for a vacation in the flesh. Take it as a sign that God is bringing you into what the fast was meant to open.

Fasting begins aggressive housecleaning. It cleans the stuff out of you. Even in the natural body, things begin to clear: buildups, waste, and what has been stored away because the system has been backed up. But the greater cleansing is in the soul and flesh.

Jesus said He would be taken away and they would sorrow. Then He compared it to a woman in travail. When the child is born, she forgets the anguish for joy that the child has come into the world. He was speaking of His going to the cross and of the new creation that would be born through His death and resurrection.

Fasting is no fun. Locking yourself away to pray through dry places is no fun. But labor does not taste like the reward. When confidence, sweet peace, glory, power, and "Here I am when You call" begin to rest on you, you forget the anguish.

I wish there were some way I could open you up and put this in you. But you have to go there yourself.

I added this because I feel grace here again, the kind where the sower catches up with the reaper. It took me twenty-six years to learn some of these things. I learned by charging into verses, employing them, and staying with them until something happened.

But if you can believe me, I can tell you what is ahead and save you years. When the sower overtakes the reaper, there is an anointing of grace that can make an adjustment inside you.

For a season hardly anyone was working miracles until Oral Roberts came on the scene. Then others sprang up. Some received anointing through association with what God had put in the earth through him. Once a gift is in the earth, others can open themselves to that grace. It is not about boasting over how many fasts someone completed or how long it took one person to receive something. It is about what God has made available.

I would to God that I could see all your dust, that you would move so fast you would leave a trail of born-again, healed people behind you. That is what this is about. Not how long it took me. Not how long it takes you. What matters is what is available in God.

Sometimes there is grace to do whatever He is calling you to do. One time we had a grace line for people having trouble reading the Bible. Another time it was for people having trouble getting into fasting. This time I feel we have nailed a kind of complacency, an emotional fight where it is hard to get yourself motivated.

You may still be serving God out of obligation and responsibility, but the joy feels attacked. It is no longer exciting to you to meet with an ecstatic God. You are missing fellowship with Him as something you can hardly wait to enter.

If that is you, and you are facing change through fasting and prayer, get aligned and let that grace pour over you. God is faithful. My prayer is that you see what I am telling you: it does not have to take forever. It takes doing the right thing, not beating the air. It takes coming under a pure move of the Spirit and a pure Word, not wasting a day or a breath.

The main thing to remember is this: the day you begin to fast is the day you decide to quit hiding from the part of you that just does not care.

You can have it.